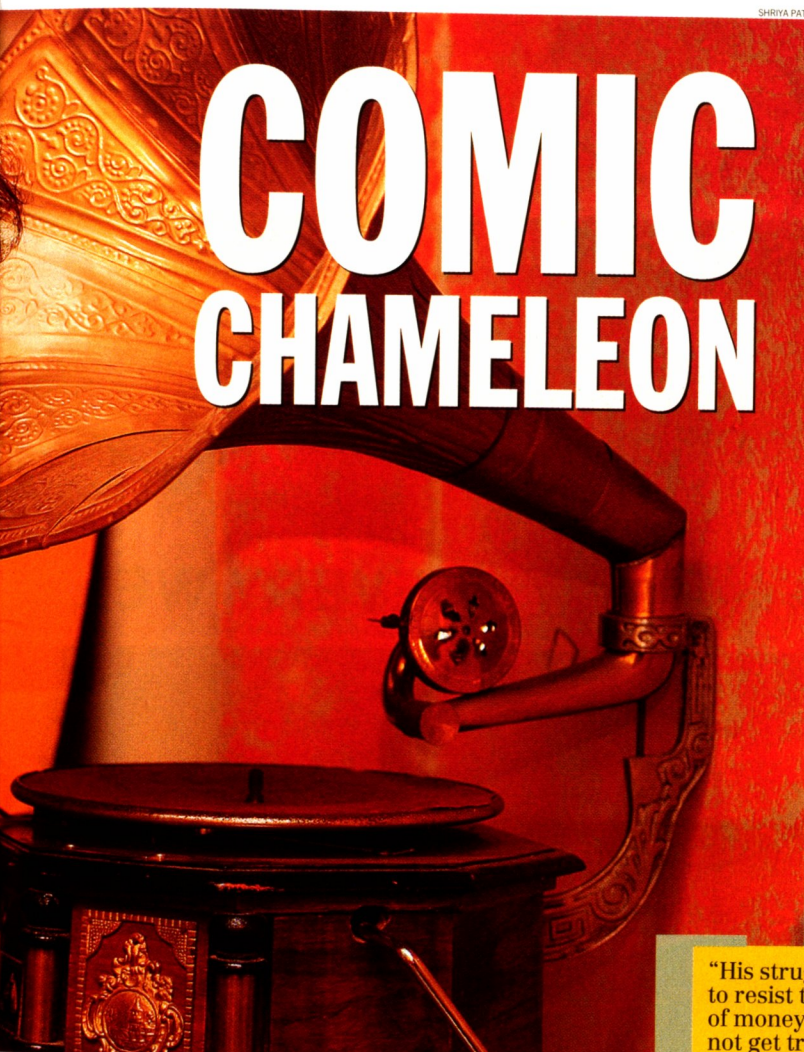




COMIC CHAMELEON

SHRUTI PATIL

the days when veejays were not just pretty people but distinctive personalities). His theatre training has given him a range and depth that directors are only too happy to exploit—how many of their actors could have played three characters, Romeo, the nurse and Friar Lawrence, in repertory productions of Shakespeare made easy for American schools?

"Initially the struggle was just to get a job that would lead to another job. Now the struggle is to find a good job to sink one's teeth into," he says. More than that, says his friend Kapoor, it is to avoid the temptation of getting trapped in the funnyman's role. But filmmakers seem to have great faith in the actor, who is married to fellow actor Sonika Sahay, with whom he has two daughters, aged five and three. His vast repertoire of training, which stretches from being able to play Chitragupta in Shashanka Ghosh's *Quick Gun Murugan* to a taxman-cum-aspiring singer in *Bheja Fry*, is able to help him prepare almost unobtrusively. It also helps him to stand up for himself—as when he walked out of the Sridevi serial on Sahara *Malini Iyer*, or when he quit anchoring for Zee TV at the beginning of his career though the Rs 4,000-a-month was more than welcome.

Pathak has been around long enough in Bollywood to know

the score. Chase good work and better co-workers. Whether it is persuading Sriram Raghavan to cast him in his next film, being appropriately humble about Aditya Chopra's praise for *Bheja Fry*, exchanging notes on weight loss with Madhuri

"His struggle will now be to resist the vast amount of money on offer and not get trapped in the funny man image."

RAJAT KAPOOR, ACTOR/DIRECTOR

"Being where Vinay is right now is wonderful for any actor who's been out of work like us."

RANVIR SHOREY, ACTOR

the forthcoming period film, *Khoya Khoya Chand*, puts it: "He would have either become typecast as the hero's sidekick or turned into an alcoholic."

He could also have made television his life—that is how he got his star-making break, playing wiseguy to Shorey's wiser guy on Channel V for two years, and then again on *The Great Indian Comedy Show*, which ran successfully on Star One for two years. Or he could have become a full-time writer, stretching the dialogues Mahesh Bhatt allowed him to pen for his role of a police officer in *Jism* (*har aadmi ke andar ek achcha kutta aur ek bura kutta hota hai*—every man has a good dog and bad dog inside him) into a full-fledged career. After all, he has already written

the successful school days serial, *Hip Hip Hurray*, for Zee TV.

It hasn't been easy. He had given up the delightful prospect of being a manager at McDonald's in the US to come back home to India at the advice of his mentor at Stonybrook—he's glad because many of his talented theatre friends are either selling furniture or doing children's theatre in Florida. He's served his dues, doing auditions for Bhansali (a monologue from *As You Like It* as well as an earthy joke full of obscenities in an Allahabadi accent) and road shows for Channel V (back in

Dixit (he is acting with her in her forthcoming comeback vehicle, *Aaja Nachle*) or even philosophising about being passed over for the role of Chunilal in Bhansali's *Devdas* because he had to cast a star (Jackie Shroff). Pathak shows a keen understanding of Bollywood protocol. Add to that unmistakable talent and it is clear that Pathak's *Bheja Fry* is not a one-time recipe for success. ■